task of writing a ‘dot-less’ commentary on the Koran, using only those Arabic alphabets which did not contain a dot. When Abu’l Fazl told Urfi that he was writing a preface for the piece, and struggling with the name of his father, Mubarak, which contained a letter with a dot, Urfi facetiously suggested the similar word Mumarak, which did not contain a dot but did, insultingly, mean ‘the indecent one’. Badauni was less appreciative of Urfi, saying of him that, despite his talents he was ‘also very haughty and pompous, which caused him to lose favour with people’. He uncharitably added that ‘he was said to be ugly to boot because of a pockmarked face’. Badauni also mentions the only Hindu poet of Persian to make it to his list of accomplished poets, Manohar ‘Tausani’, son of Raja Loonkaran of Sambhar, and a single female poet, one Nihani of Agra.

Peace reigned through most of this period but one shocking act of violence deserves mention for it led to a major reform instituted by the Padshah. It took place in the very heart of the empire—the women’s harem. In the early dawn of a spring day in 1583 there was a sudden, calamitous disturbance in the harem quarters of Fatehpur Sikri. Women were wailing while others tried to comfort them, and at the entrance to the palace, the Padshah’s bodyguards were in terrible disarray, hastily buckling on armour, grabbing weapons, and angrily shouting at each other. The Padshah, it appeared, had jumped onto his horse and had galloped away into the rising dawn in such catastrophic haste that the ever vigilant eunuchs and guards had not even had time to react. For terrible news had arrived late at night that one of his officers, Jaimal, had died en route to Bengal and his wife, the daughter of Raja Udai Singh of Marwar, affectionately called Mota Raja, was being forced to commit sati. Her own son and some ‘bold and foolish persons’ were trying to forcibly drag her onto the flames. Not wishing to waste a single minute, Akbar had ridden his horse straight to Raja Udai Singh, rescued the young widow, and imprisoned ‘the misguided ones’ till they thought better of their actions. This personal encounter with the horrors of sati radically altered Akbar’s attitude towards the practice. Up until this time, he had admired the great fortitude of women who committed sati, accepting it as a sign of their devotion to their husbands, but had not tried to interfere with the practice as it was staunchly defended by many Hindus and Rajputs at court, including Raja Bhagwant Das, his brother-in law. But now Akbar brought in measures which reflected his new recognition of the injustice it meted out to the women. ‘It is a strange commentary on the